

Maisy Hallam

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Education

- 2022 – 2026 | **PhD in Linguistics** (submission date: 22nd Feb 2026, viva date: 5th May 2026)
University of Edinburgh (Centre for Language Evolution)
Thesis: “Simplicity, Informativeness and the Emergent Structure of Kinship Terminology”
Supervised by Prof. Kenny Smith, Prof. Simon Kirby, and Prof. Fiona Jordan (University of Bristol)
- 2020 – 2021 | **MSc with Distinction in Evolution of Language and Cognition**
University of Edinburgh
Dissertation: “Investigating the effect of communication on kinship terminology with artificial language experiments”
- 2016 – 2020 | **MA with First Class Honours in Linguistics and English Language**
University of Edinburgh
Dissertation: “On the behaviour of adjective-to-noun conversion in English”

Employment

- Sept 2026 – present | **Postdoctoral Research Associate**
Max Planck Institute for Evolutionary Anthropology, Leipzig
As part of the ERC-SYNERGY grant QUANTA, I use computational and experimental methods to investigate the cultural evolution of numeral systems.
- July – Aug 2026 | **Research Assistant (“Human Testing Technician”)**
University of Edinburgh
I collaborated with Dr Shira Tal to recruit and run artificial language experiments with children, testing whether we can observe biases for communicative efficiency in their behaviour.
- 2022 – 2025 | **Tutor in Philosophy, Psychology and Language Sciences**
University of Edinburgh
I delivered tutorials and workshops across a variety of undergraduate and postgraduate courses in the Department of Philosophy, Psychology, and Language Sciences (further details below).

Publications

JOURNAL PAPERS

- 2025 | **Hallam, M., Jordan, F.M., Kirby, S. & Smith, K. (2025).** [Predictive structure emerges during the generalisation of kin terms to new referents](#). *Open Mind* 9. pp. 1431–1466.

PEER-REVIEWED CONFERENCE PROCEEDINGS

- 2026 | **Hallam, M., Kirby, S., Jordan, F.M., & Smith, K. (2026)** [Individual preferences during classification align with kinship semantics across languages](#). In Hartmann, S., Sibierska, M., Fröhlich, M., Jadoul, Y., Josserand, M., Matzinger, T., Mudd, K., Nölle, J., Pleyer, M., Waciewicz, S. & Żywiczyński, P. (Eds.): *The Evolution of Language: Proceedings of the 16th International Conference (EVLANG XVI)*.
- 2025 | **Hallam, M., Kirby, S., Jordan, F.M., & Smith, K. (2025)** [Efficient communication drives the semantic structure of kinship terminology](#). *Proceedings of the Annual Meeting of the Cognitive Science Society*, 47.
- 2024 | **Hallam, M., Jordan, F.M., Kirby, S. & Smith, K. (2024).** [Systemic structure of kinship is shaped by evolutionary processes](#). *Proceedings of the Annual Meeting of the Cognitive Science Society*, 46.

Hallam, M., Jordan, F.M., Kirby, S. & Smith, K. (2024). Systemic structure of kinship is shaped by evolutionary processes. In Nölle, J., Raviv, L., ... & Watson, S. (Eds.): *The Evolution of Language: Proceedings of the 15th International Conference (Evolang XV)*.

Shcherbakova, O., Claessens, S., **Hallam, M.**, Allasonnière-Tang, M., & Jordan, F. M. (2024). The evolution of gender-differentiated kinship terms. In Nölle, J., Raviv, L., ... & Watson, S. (Eds.): *The Evolution of Language: Proceedings of the 15th International Conference (Evolang XV)*.

Presentations

PEER-REVIEWED CONFERENCE TALKS

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| April 2026 | | Individual preferences during classification align with kinship semantics across languages
<i>International Conference on the Evolution of Language (Evolang XVI)</i> |
| Sept 2025 | | Hierarchical structure of kinship semantics derives from efficient communication principles
<i>Protolang 9</i> |
| Sept 2024 | | Variation in the kin term lexicon is not predicted by population size
<i>Cultural Evolution Society</i> |
| May 2024 | | Systemic structure of kinship is shaped by evolutionary processes
<i>International Conference on the Evolution of Language (Evolang XV)</i> |

PEER-REVIEWED CONFERENCE POSTER PRESENTATIONS

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|-----------|--|---|
| Jul 2025 | | Efficient communication drives the semantic structure of kinship terminology
<i>Annual Meeting of the Cognitive Science Society</i> |
| Jul 2024 | | Systemic structure of kinship is shaped by evolutionary processes
<i>Annual Meeting of the Cognitive Science Society</i> |
| Nov 2021 | | The origins of cross-cultural patterns in kinship systems
<i>Harvard Women in Psychology Trends in Psychology</i> |
| June 2021 | | Why do you have two grandmothers but only one mother?
<i>Linguistics and English Language Postgraduate Conference</i> |

SEMINARS

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|-----------|--|---|
| June 2025 | | It's all relative: Hierarchical constraints on kin term semantics
<i>Centre for Language Evolution seminar series</i> |
| Oct 2024 | | Evolving language in the lab: constraints on how we talk about kin
<i>University of Edinburgh Linguistics Society</i> |
| Jan 2024 | | Learning systematicity in the structure of kinship
<i>Centre for Language Evolution seminar series</i> |
| Jan 2023 | | A thousand families, all alike in terminology?
<i>Centre for Language Evolution seminar series</i> |

Teaching experience

LECTURING AND COURSE DESIGN

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| 2025 | | Evolution of Human Behaviour
In the Spring and Autumn terms, I was invited to deliver guest lectures on the biological and cultural evolution of language for students in the Department of Anthropology and Archaeology at the University of Bristol. |
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TUTORING, MARKING AND FEEDBACK

2022 – 2025	Online Experiments for Language Scientists I delivered programming labs, live coding demonstrations, and one-on-one support to students on this Honours and postgraduate course on effective experimental design and building online experiments using jsPsych.
2022 – 2024	Origins and Evolution of Language I led discussion-based tutorials for this Honours and postgraduate course on core research issues in language evolution including animal behaviour, genetics, evolutionary theory, computer modelling, and archaeology.
2022 – 2023	PPLS Skills Centre: Writing One-on-one consultations helping undergraduate and postgraduate students improve their academic writing. PPLS Skills Centre: Introduction to Python Short course helping students learn Python, from basic programming tasks to data visualisation and stats.

WORKSHOPS

2024	Time-travelling with Statistics: an intro to phylogenetic comparative methods for linguists <i>Centre for Language Evolution annual retreat</i> I designed and facilitated this two-hour session introducing phylogenetic statistical analysis in R and its practical use in language evolutionary research.
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Funding

2022 – 2026	ESRC-funded PhD Studentship <i>Scottish Graduate School of Social Science</i>
2023	National Science Foundation (NSF) <i>HRAF Summer Institute for cross-cultural anthropological research</i>

Awards and recognition

2026	James Hurford Prize for Best Student Talk <i>International Conference for Language Evolution (EVOLANG XVI); Bulgaria</i> For my talk <i>Individual preferences during classification align with kin term semantics across languages</i> .
2024	Best Small Data-Driven Project <i>Centre for Culture, Data and Society</i> For my typological work on the higher-order structure of kinship terminology systems.
2023	Three Minute Thesis University Finalist <i>University of Edinburgh</i>
2020	Patterson Prize for research in Old English <i>University of Edinburgh</i>

Academic community

REVIEWS

Journals	<i>Language and Cognition, Nature</i>
Conferences	Annual Meeting of the Cognitive Science Society (2023–2025)

EVENTS ORGANISATION

2023 – 2026	Centre for Language Evolution Seminar A weekly hybrid talk series with 20+ attendees.
Nov 2023	Edinburgh Lectures in Language Evolution 2023 A four-part serial hybrid talk series with over 200 attendees.

COPYEDITING AND PROOFREADING

2019 – 2020	Journal for the Undergraduate Linguistics Association of Britain (JouLAB)
2018	Second Language Phonology between Cognition and Use by Nadia Boucchioua

OUTREACH	
2025	‘Monkeys: Our Primate Family’ at the National Museum of Scotland I gave a workshop on what animal communication can tell us about human language and cognition as part of the National Museum’s exhibit on primatology.
2024 – 2025	PPLS Perspectives (two times episode host) A podcast exploring cutting-edge research in philosophy, psychology and language sciences at the University of Edinburgh.
2022 – 2023	Language Evolves! A pop linguistics workshop for children at local schools organised by the Centre for Language Evolution.

Skills

Languages	English (native), French (B1), British Sign Language (A2)
Programming & markup	Python, R, JavaScript, HTML, TeX
Data analysis	lme4, tidyverse, BRMS, ape, pandas
Experiments	jsPsych, Prolific
Other	Git, Microsoft Office, Affinity Designer, InDesign, Audacity